

relationship:

The first is **understanding ourselves and our values**. It's essentially what this whole book is about. When we have a good grasp on who we are, what's important to us, and the goals we want to achieve, we are less likely to be blindly influenced into spending decisions or lifestyle shifts that aren't for us.

But when we spend based on someone else's values, out of compulsion, obligation, or pressure, we're the ones most impacted. We're left with stuff we don't need or want, lifestyles that aren't fulfilling, trips that incurred debt, brunches with subpar food, and a feeling of defeat that leads us back to thinking "If I had more money, this problem would be solved." As we've said earlier, more money would be great! But if we learned anything from Haley and Justin's muffin moment, we know that if simply "more money" is the metric, then no amount will ever be "enough." Especially when our idea of enough is not tied to intentional actions rooted in personal values. This knowledge of self and what's important to you can't be understated—it's the secret sauce behind an ability to keep scrolling past the IG ad, skip Target's Dollar Spot, and ultimately say easier noes and better yeses around your spending.

You might be thinking, "Yea, yea, yea, *know thyself*, but what if it's not a *me* problem, it's a *them* problem?" You're not alone! This second concept is key, and it involves **establishing boundaries and speaking your needs**. If you struggle with people-pleasing, have a hard time saying no, deal with fears of missing out, or have a pulse, you need boundaries!

In my work as a mental health therapist, boundaries were the number one thing we talked about behind closed doors. Discerning what is and is not OK, identifying needs, taking responsibility for oneself, measuring emotional/mental/relational capacity, and learning how to operate within and out of those realities. Our conversations almost always came back to boundaries. And it's no different with relationships and money!

Barring traumatic situations and abusive relationships, we train people how to treat us. We get to decide what is in bounds and what is out of bounds, and we can respond accordingly. The trouble is societal pressure, cultural expectations, and an innate desire for belonging intersecting with our best-laid plans. We will allow others to take from us or give us things we don't want. Boundaries are the parameters we get to operate within—they define the context for our creativity. And like we said in chapter 3,